that's been used over the past couple of years either. The human element is part and parcel of cricket, and you've got to take the good with the bad, I reckon. I think all this referring nonsense undermines the guys on the field. The umpires have been standing there for hours and then, when they're asked to make a decision, the players want someone else to give a second opinion? I mean, what's that all about?

You've got to feel for the umps. They must be wondering why they even bother going out there on the pitch other than to hold the players' jerseys, hats and sunglasses. They may as well just plant a hat stand out at point and another behind the bowler's stumps. I don't know about you, but I'd rather have someone like Billy Bowden and his legendary antics out there in the middle than a hat stand. I love all his crazy signals – especially his ultra-quirky 20/20 versions. And the guy very rarely makes a mistake. Simon Taufel, who was the ICC's Umpire of the Year between 2004 and 2008, and Aleem Dar, the current holder of the crown, are also excellent umpires.

To be honest, I've never had one guy umpiring a game I've played in who's made me think, 'Okay, here comes trouble.' Sure, I've been given some kak decisions, but I've also had a few go my way. I recall Dave Orchard giving me a shocker in a domestic game – this must've been, like, 10 years ago – but afterwards he came up to me and apologised. I remember him saying, 'I got that one wrong. Next time, I owe you.'

Obviously, when it's a big nick, it's easy to call. Everyone hears the nick and there's no point in hanging around – you just look like an idiot if you stay there. But there are times when the touch is so faint that you're not even sure whether you touched it or not; I mean, I don't know how the hell an *umpire* is supposed to know. In such a case, I'll definitely stick around and wait for the finger.

The funny thing about batsmen is that their desire to walk (or not) is often determined by their form. If they're going through a bad trot, they very rarely walk when they nick the ball. If they've had a good run of form, though, and they are scoring runs consistently, they will often walk when they nick one. In other words, it's a lot easier to show your more honourable qualities when you have some runs in the bank.

But World Cups are a different story. Well, for me, anyway. I *never* want to go out in a World Cup match. And I have nicked a ball in a World Cup game – I knew it, the fielding team knew it – but I stood my ground, as I am entitled to do … and the ump turned down the appeal. Bladdy miracle!